Then as winter approached and the Indian land-mass began to cool, the winds reversed, allowing them to go home with their sails again filled – as well as their holds. Given these long-established trading links with the Malabaris and the rapid spread of Islam within Arabia it is more than probable that there were very early Indian converts to Islam among the colonies of Arab traders settled on the Malabar coast – where their descendants are to be found to this day. However, that an Indian ruler converted to Islam during the lifetime of the Prophet is more questionable. We simply do not know, although the traveller Ibn Battuta tells us that the rulers of the Maldives converted to Islam in the twelfth century. The first European account of Cheraman Perumal's conversion comes from a Portuguese named Duarte Barbosa, who came to Kerala in 1510 and recorded that these events had taken place six hundred years before the arrival of the Portuguese, which would place the conversion of Cheraman in about 898.

The name their Indian hosts gave these early Arab Muslim settlers was Mussulman Mappila, the first word derived from the Arab *Muslimeen*, 'those who submit', the second from the Tamil for 'son-in-law', which demonstrates that they were welcomed and found local wives. Thanks to the local caste prohibitions, the sea-faring skills of these Mappilas were much sought after, so much so that in later years the Hindu rulers known as the Zamorins of Calicut made it compulsory for every family of Hindu fishermen to give one son to Islam so that he could be trained as a sailor. The horses the Arabs imported were equally prized, as was the horsemanship they brought with them. Horses were always a rare and valuable commodity in India, being vulnerable to climate and disease, so that their stocks were constantly having to be replenished. As a result, the 'Arab' became a key element in the Indo-Arabian trade balance, and one of the oldest Muslim communities in South India are the Ravuttanas, a word derived from the Tamil for 'cavalryman',